



The Coach Who Won Everything but the Last Game

Student copy (project or hand out)

- 1 Rick Adelman died on June 1, sixteen days short of his eightieth birthday. He won 1,042 games as an NBA coach, the tenth most in the history of the league. He never won a championship.
- 2 Those two facts sat beside each other for his whole career, and they sit beside each other still. The ring is the loud thing, the thing the highlight reels are cut for, the thing a city throws a parade around. The win total is the quiet thing, accumulated one ordinary Tuesday at a time over twenty-three seasons. Adelman gave his life to the quiet thing. Twice the loud one came within reach, and twice it went elsewhere: Portland lost the 1990 Finals to Detroit in five, then lost the 1992 Finals to Chicago in six.
- 3 What he had instead was reach. He coached the Trail Blazers, the Warriors, the Kings, the Rockets, the Timberwolves. In Sacramento he made the playoffs eight straight years and took six division titles; in Houston, after Yao Ming broke his foot a dozen games into a 22-game winning streak, his team still finished 55-27. He had been a journeyman point guard before any of it, 7.7 points a night across five teams in six seasons, the kind of player nobody builds a statue for. That part of the record is just true. It explains nothing and it stays.
- 4 On April 6, 2013, in Minnesota, he beat the Pistons 107-101 and became the eighth coach ever to reach a thousand wins. He was not a man who performed for the room. The voice was level, the manner plain, the teams better than their rosters had any right to be, season after season after season.
- 5 Only four coaches in league history won more games at a higher rate, and their names are Riley, Popovich, Sloan, Karl. To stand just behind that company, and to have stood there without ever once being the loudest man in the building, is its own kind of monument. The Hall of Fame agreed in 2021.
- 6 His son David coaches the Denver Nuggets now, and learned the work at his father's side in Minnesota. The teaching did not stop; it changed offices. A thousand and forty-two wins, and not one of them the one everyone counts first. He would have told you the count was never the point. The work was.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. Which of the following best characterizes the writer's position on Adelman's lack of a championship?
 - A) It is a failure the writer works to excuse on Adelman's behalf
 - B) It is a defining absence the writer treats as secondary to the larger record of sustained excellence
 - C) It is a misfortune the writer blames on the teams that beat him
 - D) It is an oversight the writer argues the Hall of Fame should have weighed more heavily

2. In the third paragraph, the writer places the eight-year Sacramento playoff run beside Houston finishing 55-27 after Yao Ming's injury primarily to
- A) demonstrate the breadth of his durability across different rosters
 - B) establish the loud-versus-quiet opposition the whole tribute is built on
 - C) attribute the strong Houston record to Yao Ming's eventual return
 - D) prove he was the most adaptable coach of his era

Discussion questions:

1. The piece never states in plain words that Adelman was great; it arranges facts so the reader concludes it. Where does the writing do this work, and is the indirect method more or less persuasive than simply asserting his greatness?
2. The closing lines distinguish 'the count' from 'the work.' What is the difference the writer draws between them, and how does the rest of the opener prepare that distinction?

Writing prompt (Homework or extended in-class, Q2 rhetorical analysis):

The following passage is a tribute published after the death of Hall of Fame NBA coach Rick Adelman in June 2026. Read the passage carefully. Then write an essay that analyzes the rhetorical choices the writer makes to honor Adelman and to shape the reader's understanding of his career. In your response you should: respond to the prompt with a defensible thesis that analyzes the writer's rhetorical choices; select and use evidence to support your line of reasoning; explain how the evidence supports your line of reasoning; and demonstrate an understanding of the rhetorical situation. Consider, among other choices, the writer's use of antithesis, sentence structure, and the placement of facts.